A (More) Objective View of AI

Implications for the Future

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1. Introduction

AI Is Not Going Away

- **AI is not going away**. Blindly refusing AI is not the solution. Instead, it is fundamental to understand its capabilities and limitations.

> *"Love it or hate it, artificial intelligence (AI) is here, and it's not going away. As the technology evolves, AI will only become more prominent in our everyday interactions, shaping everything from how students learn to the work employees do at the office."* [1]
>
> — **AI Won't Take Your Job if You Know About IA**, Harvard Graduate School of Education, 2024

[1] AI Won't Take Your Job if You Know About IA - Dede & McCool, Harvard Graduate School of Education, 2024

2. Unlikely Exponential Growth

- **Fundamental Physical Limits of Transistors and Memory**.
  - The thermodynamic minimum gate length of a *transistor* will likely be reached by 2030, while the limits of photolithography are expected around 2029. [2]
  - *Memory bandwidth* has been increasing far more slowly than FLOP/s, at 30x in the last 20 years (1.5x/2yr), while FLOP/s have increased 90,000x in the same period (3x/2yr). This is a much more conservative constraint on potential AI growth. [3, 4]

[2] The Transistor Cliff - S. Constantin, 2023

[3] AI and Memory Wall - Gholami et al., IEEE Micro, 2024

[4] Challenges and Research Directions for Large Language Model Inference Hardware - Ma and Patterson, Google, 2026

- **Hardware Resource Constraints**. Reconstructing one cubic millimeter of human temporal cortex (~50-57k cells and ~130-150M synapses) generated 1.4 Petabytes of data. Scaling to the full human brain would require 1.6 zettabytes of storage costing $50 billion and spanning 140 acres. [5, 6]

- **Datacenters require 24/7 energy**. Solar and wind energy are not suitable for this purpose. On average, a nuclear power plant takes about 9.4 years to build, with an additional 3-4 years for the licensing process. [7]

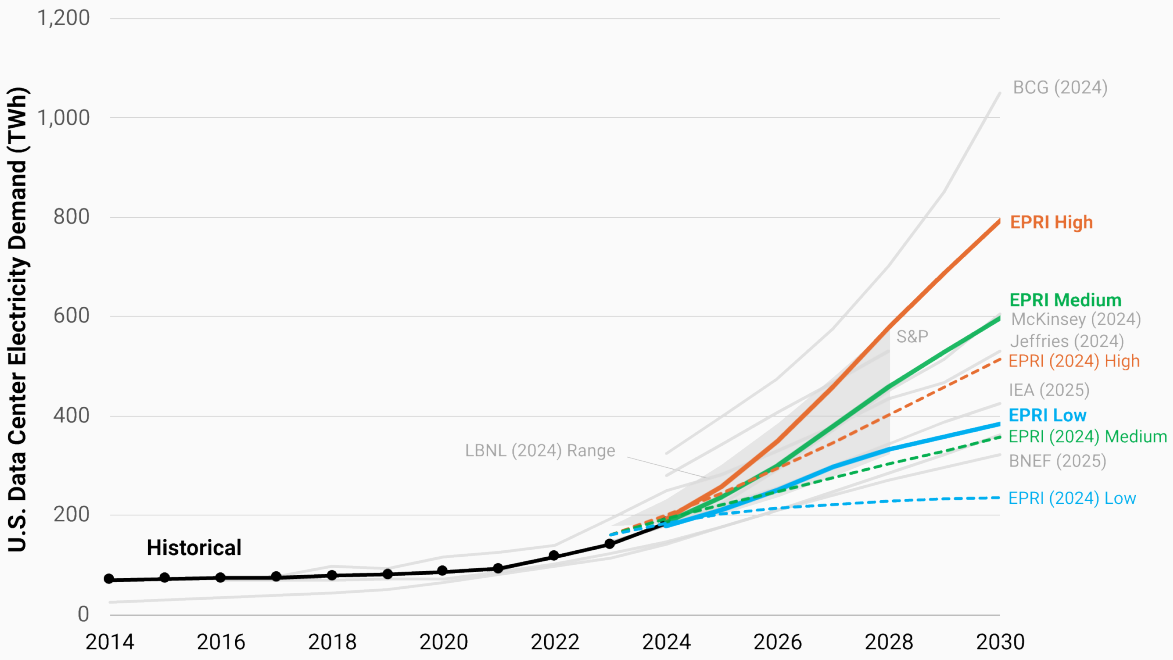
[5] A Browsable Petascale Reconstruction of the Human Cortex - Blakely et al., Google, 2021

[6] Full scan of 1 cubic millimeter of brain tissue took 1.4 petabytes of data, equivalent to 14,000 4K movies - S. Grimm, Tom's Hardware, 2024

[7] Global nuclear reactor construction starts and duration, 1949-2023 - Cleveland & Mirkova, Boston University, 2024

Unlikely Exponential Growth

*"**The data center share of U.S. total electricity demand in 2030 ranges from 9% to 17%, an increase from 4-5% today**. At the state level, continued development of the largest DC market in Virginia implies a share increasing to between 39% and 57% by 2030."*



[8] Powering Intelligence 2026 - EPRI, 2026

Unlikely Exponential Growth

- **Running out of data**. AI training will exhaust its data by 2027, or by 2032 if the rate of computing growth slows down. [9]

- **AI quality degradation when trained on recursively generated data**. AI-generated content has surpassed the *quantity* of human-written articles. This implies that AI models are trained on increasingly low-quality data, reinforcing hallucinations. [10], [11], [12], [13]

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[9] Will we run out of data? Limits of LLM scaling based on human-generated data - Villalobos et al., EpochAI, 2024

[10] More Articles Are Now Created by AI Than Humans - Paredes et al., Graphite, 2025

[11] AI models collapse when trained on recursively generated data - Shumailov et al., Nature, 2024

[12] A Shocking Amount of the Web is Machine Translated: Insights from Multi-Way Parallelism - Thompson et al., Association for Computational Linguistics, 2024

[13] 74% of New Webpages Include AI Content (Study of 900k Pages) - Law et al., Ahrefs, 2025

3. Productivity Gain Uncertainty

Productivity Gain Uncertainty

- The relationship between AI adoption and evidence of productivity gains is a *controversial topic*. Some research studies and economic data suggest that AI enhances productivity, while others show no benefits or even a negative impact.

> *"The AI productivity story in early 2026 is neither the revolution that vendors promise nor the disappointment that skeptics predict* ***-it's a transition whose timeline remains genuinely uncertain****.*
>
> *... History suggests AI's macro impact may similarly require a decade of complementary innovation before the statistics catch up to the promise."* [14]
>
> — **AI Productivity's $4 Trillion Question: Hype, Hope, And Hard Data**, Forbes, 2026

[14] AI Productivity's $4 Trillion Question: Hype, Hope, And Hard Data - G. Yildiz, Forbes, 2026

Productivity Gain Uncertainty - No Benefits 1/4

"Combine the increase in working hours spent using generative AI with how much it improves efficiency, and you get a boost of about ***0.25-0.5 percentage points to productivity growth over the past year. This calculation is almost certainly too generous.****"* [15]

— **The AI productivity boom is not here (yet)**,
The Economist, 2026

[15] The AI productivity boom is not here (yet) - The Economist, 2026

Productivity Gain Uncertainty - No Benefits

*"AI will increase productivity and GDP by **1.5% by 2035**, nearly 3% by 2055, and 3.7% by 2075. AI's boost to annual productivity growth is strongest in the early 2030s but eventually fades"* [16]

— **The Projected Impact of Generative AI on Future Productivity Growth**,
University of Pennsylvania, 2025

*"Surprisingly, we find that when developers use AI tools, they **take 19% longer than without – AI makes them slower**."* [17]

— **Measuring the Impact of Early-2025 AI on Experienced Open-Source Developer Productivity**,
METR, 2025

[16] The Projected Impact of Generative AI on Future Productivity Growth - Arnon et al., University of Pennsylvania, 2025

[17] Measuring the Impact of Early-2025 AI on Experienced Open-Source Developer Productivity - Becker et al., METR, 2025

Productivity Gain Uncertainty - No Benefits

*"Despite widespread experimentation, **only one-in-eight (12%) CEOs say AI has delivered both cost and revenue benefits**. Overall, 33% report gains in either cost or revenue, while 56% say they have seen no significant financial benefit to date."* [18]

— **PwC 2026 Global CEO Survey**,
(4,454 EXECUTIVES IN 95 COUNTRIES)

[18] CEO confidence in revenue outlook hits five-year low - PwC 2026 Global CEO Survey, 2026

Productivity Gain Uncertainty - No Benefits

"Firms report little impact of AI over the last 3 years, with ***over 80% of firms reporting no impact on either employment or productivity****. Firms predict sizable impacts over the next 3 years, forecasting AI will boost productivity by 1.4%"* [19]

— **Firm Data on AI**,
National Bureau of Economic Research, 2026
(6000 senior executives, across US, UK, Germany, Australia)

[19] Firm Data on AI - National Bureau of Economic Research, 2026

Productivity Gain Uncertainty - Mixed Benefits 1/2

"AI tools didn't reduce work, they ***consistently intensified it****.*

... We identified three main forms of intensification: task expansion, blurred boundaries between work and non-work, and more multitasking.

... For workers, the cumulative effect is fatigue, burnout, and a growing sense that work is harder to step away from." [20]

— **AI Doesn't Reduce Work-It Intensifies It**,
Harvard Business Review

[20] AI Doesn't Reduce Work-It Intensifies It - Ranganathan & Ye, Harvard Business Review, 2026

Work is accelerating faster than the systems designed to manage it.

... Focus efficiency, the percentage of work time spent in focused, uninterrupted activity, declined to 60% – a three-year low. Risk of disengagement jumped 23%.

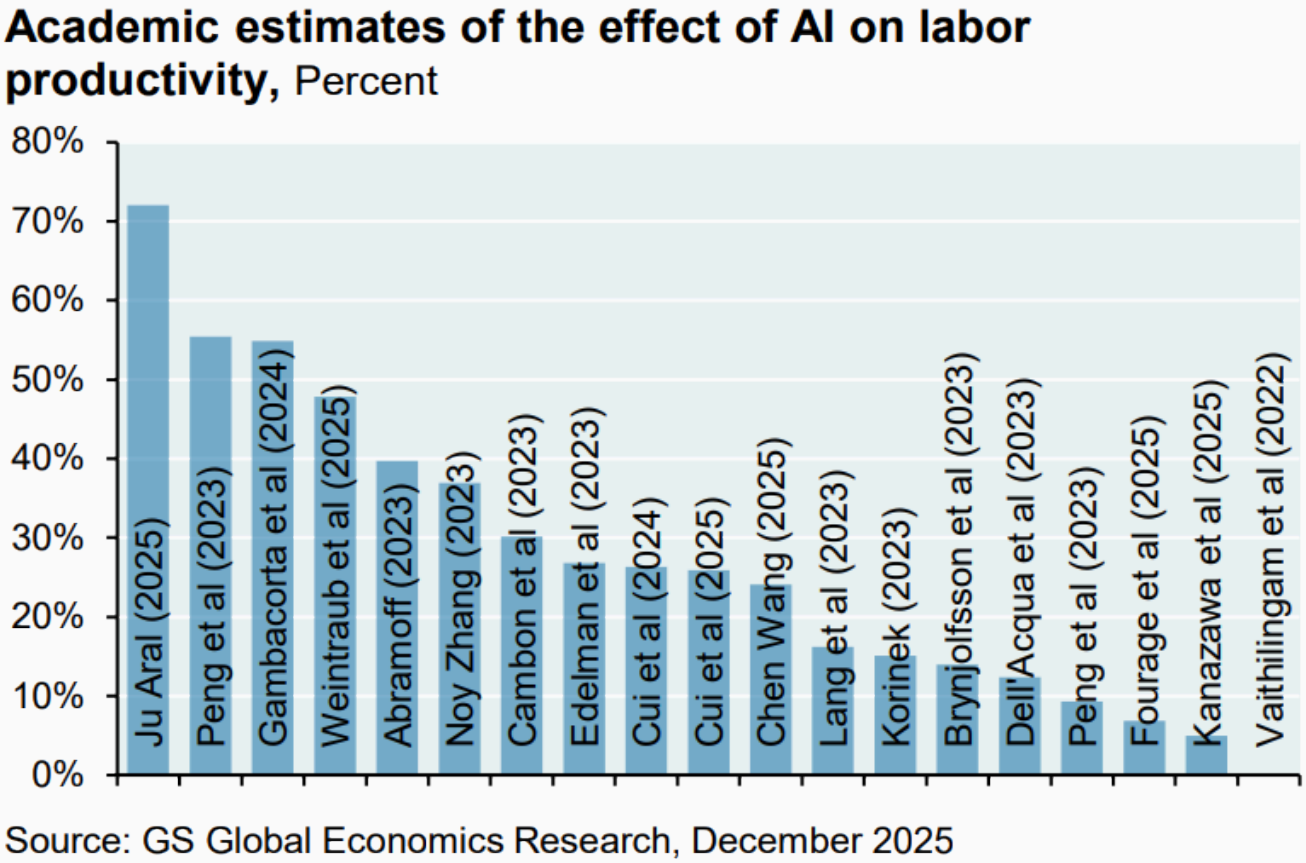
... AI is adding to workloads rather than redistributing them. Collaboration is expanding faster than attention can support it. Productivity gains are real but increasingly funded by fragmentation rather than depth.

... The data is unambiguous: AI does not reduce workloads. AI is being used as an additional productivity layer, not a substitute for existing work. [21]

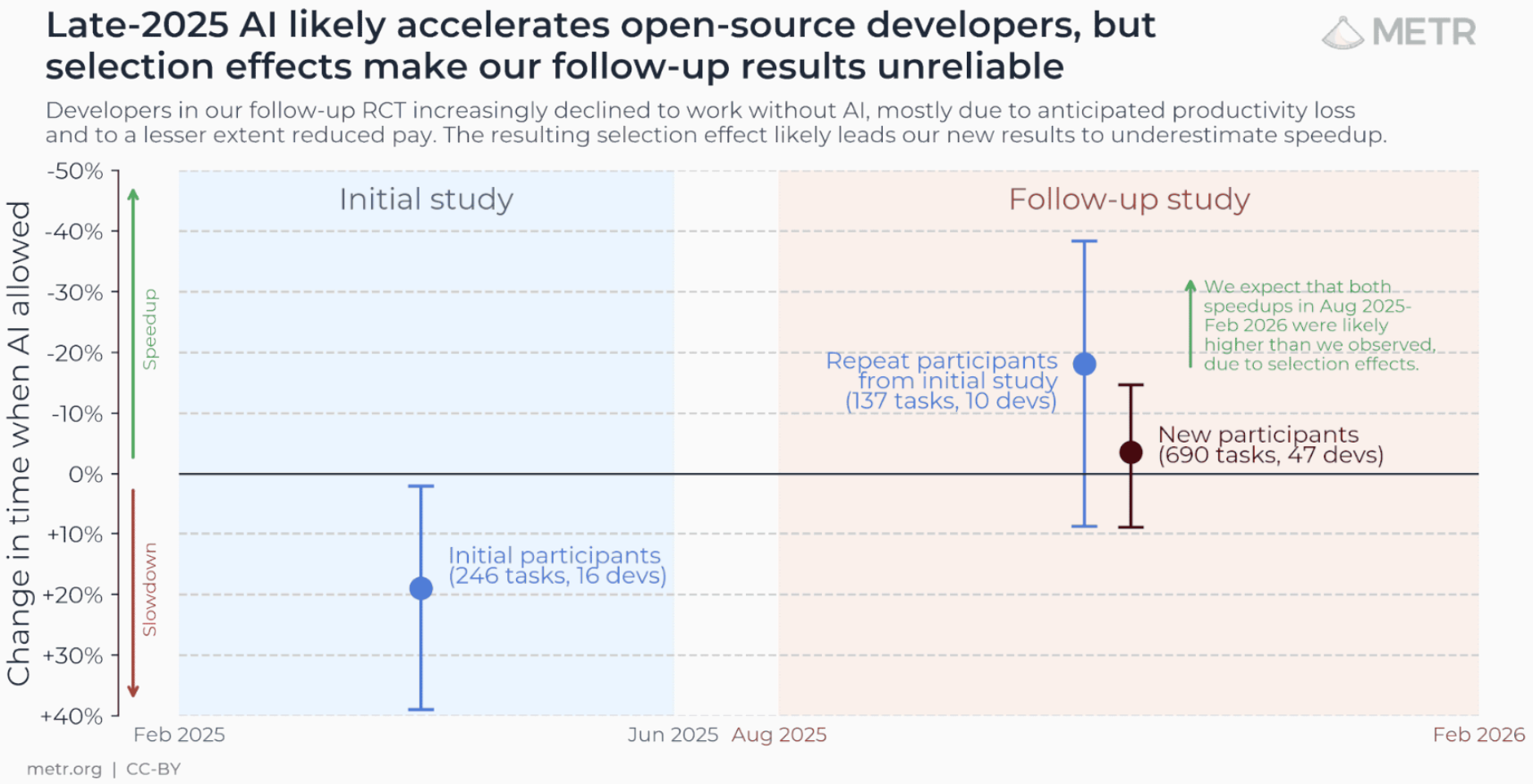
— **2026 State of the Workplace**,
ActivTrak, 2026

[21] 2026 State of the Workplace - ActivTrak, 2026

Productivity Gain Uncertainty - Increased by AI



[22] Smothering Heights - M. Cembalest, J.P. Morgan, 2026



[23] We are Changing our Developer Productivity Experiment Design - Becker et al., METR, 2026

Productivity Gain Uncertainty - Increased by AI

Across 515 high-growth startups, we run a field experiment in which treated firms receive information about how other firms have reorganized production around AI, prompting them to search for use cases across a broader set of firm functions. We find that treated firms discover more AI use cases, a 44% increase, concentrated in product development and strategy. These changes result in economically meaningful performance gains. ***Treated firms complete 12% more tasks, are 18% more likely to acquire paying customers, and generate 1.9x higher revenue.*** [24]

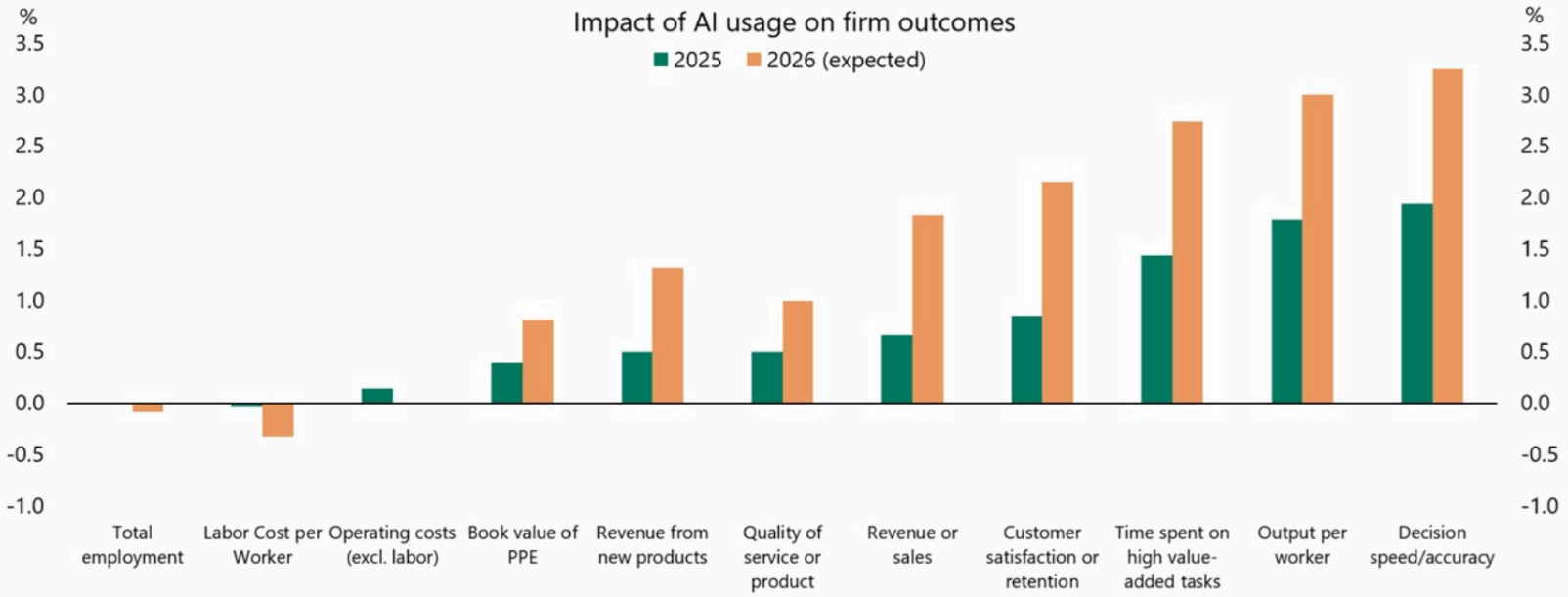
— **Mapping AI into Production: A Field Experiment on Firm Performance**, The Business School of the World, 2026

[24] Mapping AI into Production: A Field Experiment on Firm Performance - Kim et al., The Business School of the World, 2026

Productivity Gain Uncertainty - Increased by AI

APOLLO

Channels through which AI is expected to have an impact on businesses



Note: Question asks for Likert scale options that are mapped to percentage outcomes (i.e., increased moderately, 5.1 to 10%). Above chart uses midpoint of ranges provided and +/-5% above/below highest/lowest options to calculate numeric averages across respondents. Sources: The CFO Survey, Federal Reserve Bank of Richmond, Apollo Chief Economist

[25] The AI Revolution Continues - T. Slok, Apollo Global Management, 2026

4. Employment

Productivity Gain and Labor Markets

*"Across domains, **AI is better at amplifying human judgment than at replacing it**, rewarding those who can evaluate outputs and decide how to direct them toward useful ends.*

*... By making execution cheap, AI shifts value upstream toward cognitive tasks-judgment, problem framing, and integration–that are unevenly distributed and slow to acquire. As a result, access to AI alone is unlikely to equalize outcomes. **What matters is not whether workers can use AI but whether they can turn its output into useful work.**"*

— **AI raises the productivity bar**,
SCIENCE, 2026

[26] AI raises the productivity bar - WU & VASILESCU, SCIENCE, 2026

"AI has become the most powerful proactive frame available. 'We're restructuring around AI' is a growth signal. 'We over-hired during the pandemic and revenue softened' is an accountability signal.

... What makes AI washing corrosive is the confusion it creates, both inside and outside companies.

*... **And every incoherent account adds to the public's conviction that AI is eliminating jobs at a pace the data simply do not support.**"* [27]

— **The 'AI-Washing' of Job Cuts Is Corrosive and Confusing**, Bloomberg, 2026

[27] The 'AI-Washing' of Job Cuts Is Corrosive and Confusing - G. Mukunda, Bloomberg, 2026

*"**A flood of sometimes conflicting analyses shows the yawning gap between what little is known about how AI is changing work and everyone's understandable hunger for certainty**.*

... Economists say it's nearly impossible to forecast AI's effect on the labor market from the current capabilities of the technology or the business sectors it's seeping into first." [28]

— **See which jobs are most threatened by AI and who may be able to adapt**, The Washington Post, 2026

[28] See which jobs are most threatened by AI and who may be able to adapt - Schaul & Shira, The Washington Post, 2026

*"**we're sceptical that firms can quickly and seamlessly substitute workers with AI even in sectors where the potential for AI disruption is greatest**. What's more, some surveys suggest that AI use in larger US firms has recently stalled.*

*... Data from Challenger, Gray and Christmas suggests that AI-related US job losses are snowballing. In the first 11 months of 2025, AI was cited as a reason for almost 55,000 US job cuts, which accounts for over 75% of the reported AI-related job losses since the reason was first cited in 2023. However, these 55,000 or **so many AI-related job losses above account for only 4.5% of total reported job losses in the report**."* [29]

— **Evidence of an AI-driven shakeup of job markets is patchy**, Oxford Economics, 2026

[29] Evidence of an AI-driven shakeup of job markets is patchy - Oxford Economics, 2026

*"Despite headlines, **AI isn't the culprit behind slow hiring**. LinkedIn data shows **economic uncertainty, and monetary policy shifts are the primary drivers**. Advanced economies are struggling the most, with hiring down 20%-35% compared to pre-pandemic levels.*

*... Many roles as we have known them will undergo this transformation into new collar. In the past two years, **employers have created at least 1.3 million AI-related job opportunities.**"* [30]

— **Labor Market Report**,
LinkedIn, 2026

[30] Labor Market Report - LinkedIn, 2026

We find that thus far, ***there is no evidence of a reduction in job postings for industries or firms which have higher levels of AI adoption****. The overall slowdown in national job postings following the pandemic recovery does not appear to be driven (even modestly) by AI.* [31]

— **FEDS Notes**, 2026

[31] FEDS Notes - Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System, 2026

*"Micro-level evidence suggests that AI generates **meaningful time savings** for many workers. At the macro level, in recent years industries with higher AI adoption rates have **experienced faster productivity growth**. While we do not establish causality, this relationship is statistically significant and similar in magnitude in Europe and the US."* [32]

— **Mind the Gap: AI Adoption in Europe and the U.S.**, National Bureau of Economic Research, 2026

[32] Mind the Gap: AI Adoption in Europe and the U.S. - National Bureau of Economic Research, 2026

"While anxiety over the effects of AI on today's labor market is widespread, our data suggests it remains largely speculative. The picture of AI's impact on the labor market that emerges from our data is one that ***largely reflects stability, not major disruption at an economy-wide level****."* [33]

— **Evaluating the Impact of AI on the Labor Market: Current State of Affairs**, Budgetlab, Yale University, 2025

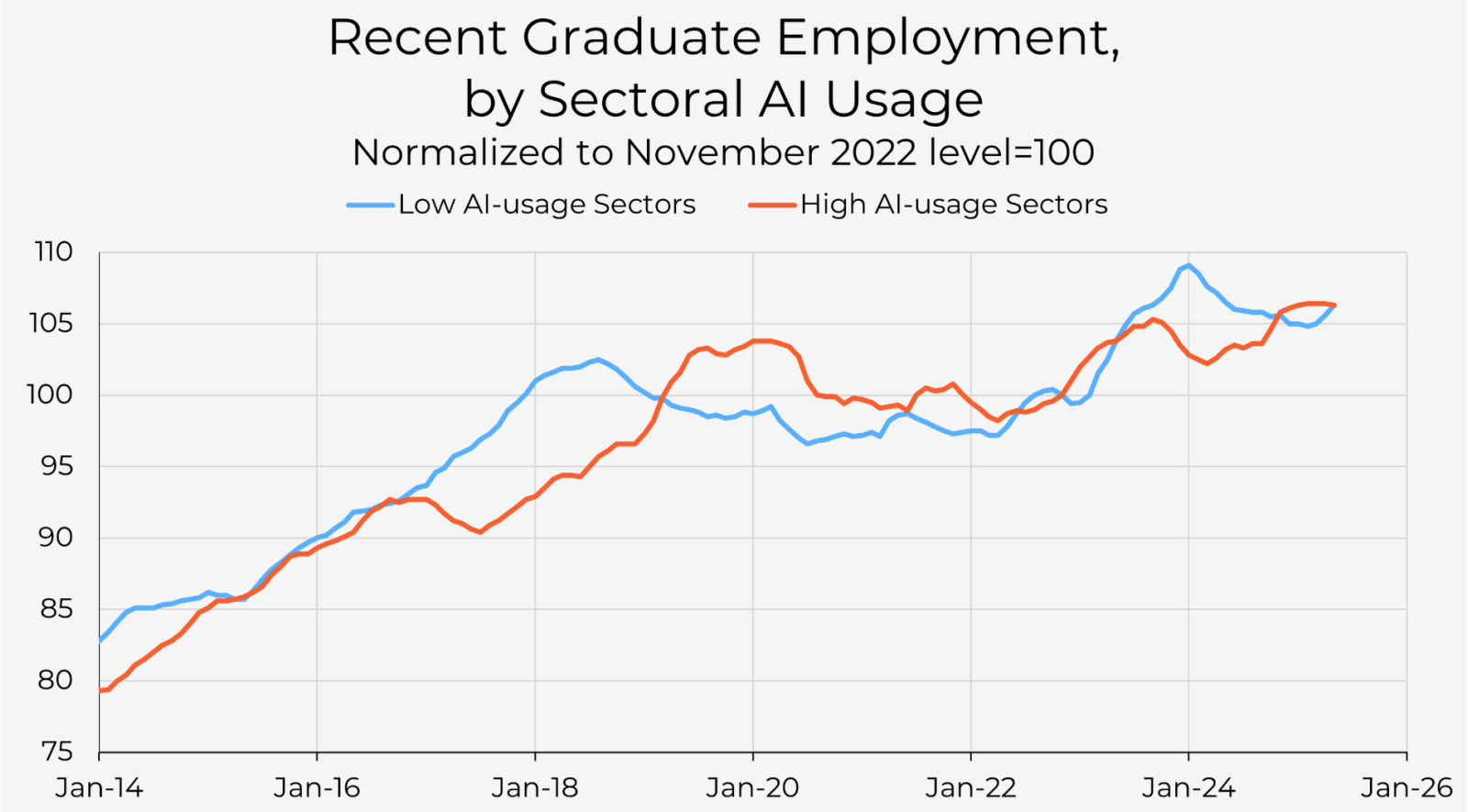
[33] Evaluating the Impact of AI on the Labor Market: Current State of Affairs - Gimbel et al., Budgetlab, Yale University, 2025

"Young workers of all education levels are lagging the rest of the labor market. ***Focusing too much on education rather than age as the main labor market weakness starts us in the wrong direction****.*

So is AI nonetheless to blame for the broad-based weakness in the labor market for young people? It's true that some lower-skilled jobs can be replaced by AI. Call center workers and data entry jobs are potential examples. But there are not enough of these jobs to really drive the youth labor market." [34]

— **AI and Young-adult Jobs: The Real Mystery**,
Economic Innovation Group, 2026

[34] AI and Young-adult Jobs: The Real Mystery - Ozimek & Goldschlag, Economic Innovation Group, 2026


Recent Graduate Employment,
by Sectoral AI Usage
Normalized to November 2022 level=100
Low AI-usage Sectors
High AI-usage Sectors
110
105
100
95
90
85
80
75
Jan-14
Jan-16
Jan-18
Jan-20
Jan-22
Jan-24
Jan-26

[35] Don't Blame AI For The Rise in Recent Graduate Unemployment - W. Raderman, Employ America, 2026

"the association between LLM performance and task duration is well approximated by a relatively flat, near-linear relationship rather than a steep, wave-like pattern.

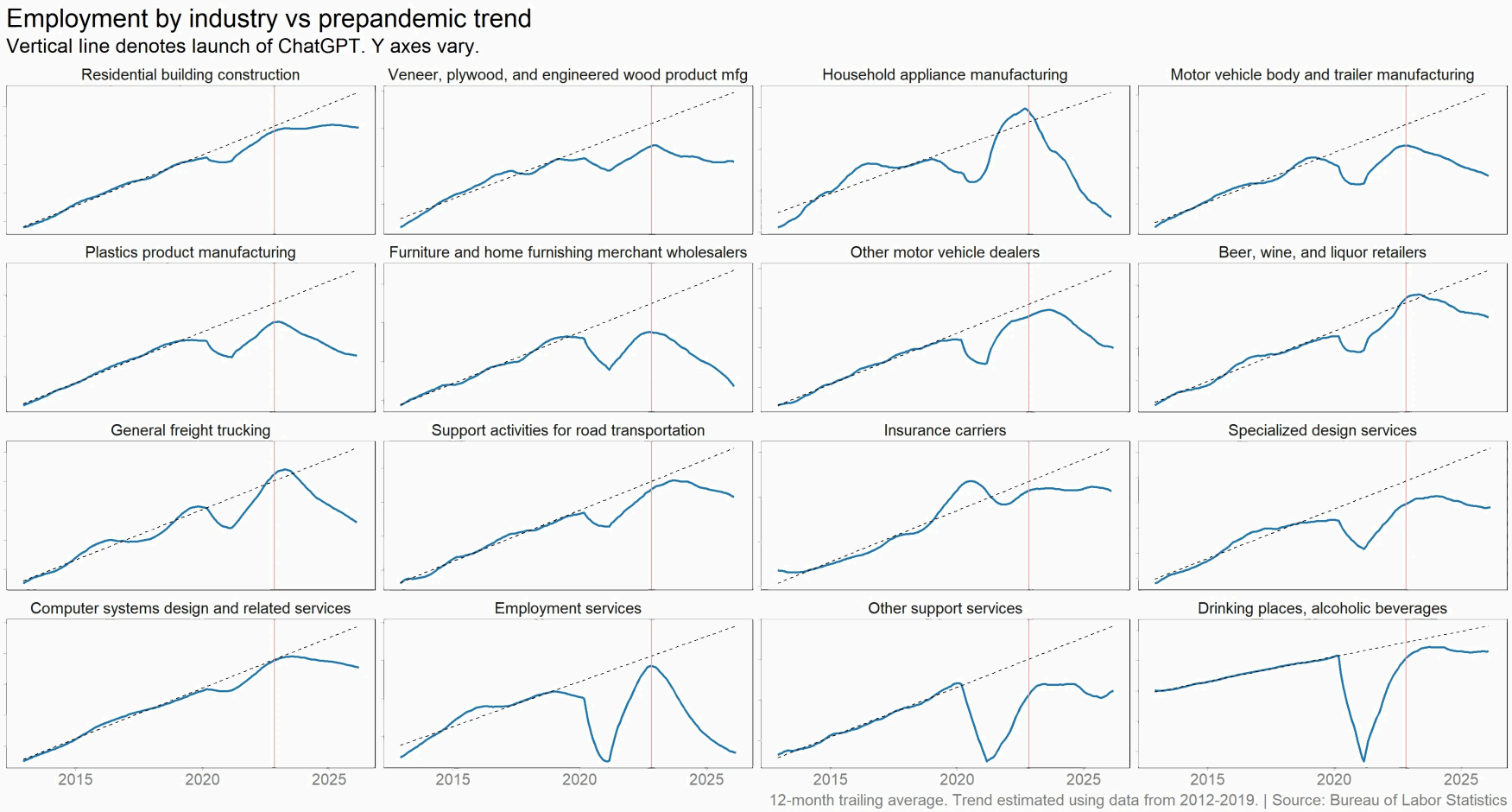
... the success rates achieved by LLMs in this analysis should not be interpreted as implying that a corresponding share of tasks can (or should) be automated today

*... **the loss of individual tasks does not necessarily hurt the employees**. Indeed, based on the expertise of task and how that relates to the occupation's bundle of tasks, automation could increase or decrease wages.*

*... In particular, **we require each task instance to be self-contained**, with all relevant information provided in the prompt. This constraint limits our ability to represent tasks that depend on interaction with external artifacts"*

— **Crashing Waves vs. Rising Tides: Preliminary Findings on AI Automation from Thousands of Worker Evaluations of Labor Market Tasks**, Economic Innovation Group, 2026

[36] Crashing Waves vs. Rising Tides: Preliminary Findings on AI Automation from Thousands of Worker Evaluations of Labor Market Tasks - Mertens et al., arXiv, 2026


Employment by industry vs prepandemic trend
Vertical line denotes launch of ChatGPT. Y axes vary.
Residential building construction
Veneer, plywood, and engineered wood product mfg
Household appliance manufacturing
Motor vehicle body and trailer manufacturing
Plastics product manufacturing
Furniture and home furnishing merchant wholesalers
Other motor vehicle dealers
Beer, wine, and liquor retailers
General freight trucking
Support activities for road transportation
Insurance carriers
Specialized design services
Computer systems design and related services
Employment services
Other support services
Drinking places, alcoholic beverages
2015
2020
2025
12-month trailing average. Trend estimated using data from 2012-2019. | Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics

Employment

[37] Employment by Industry - B. Casselman, Chief Economics Correspondent for The New York Times, 2026

5. Positive Impacts

Protein Structure Prediction

"In 2020, Demis Hassabis and John Jumper presented an AI model called ***AlphaFold2****. With its help, they have been able to* ***predict the structure of virtually all the 200 million proteins*** *that researchers have identified. Since their breakthrough,* ***AlphaFold2 has been used by more than two million people from 190 countries****. Among a myriad of scientific applications, researchers can now better understand antibiotic resistance and create images of enzymes that can decompose plastic."* [38]

— **AlphaFold2**,
Nobel Prize in Chemistry, 2024

[38] AlphaFold2 - Nobel Prize in Chemistry, 2024

Material Discovery

"With GNoME, we've multiplied the number of technologically viable materials known to humanity. Of its 2.2 million predictions, 380,000 are the most stable, ***making them promising candidates for experimental synthesis****."* [39]

— **GNoME**, DeepMind, 2023

"The open-access materials database … enabling AI-ready scientific datasets at an unprecedented scale for batteries, quantum computing, microelectronics, and more.

… in 650,000+ registered users, 32,000+ scientific journal citations, ~5,000 active users a day, 200,000+ materials, 577,000+ molecules, 465+ TBs of data, 300 million+ data requests a year." [40]

— **The Materials Project**, Berkeley Lab, 2026

[39] Millions of new materials discovered with deep learning - Merchant & Cubuk, DeepMind, 2023

[40] Accelerating Discovery: How the Materials Project Is Helping to Usher in the AI Revolution for Materials Science - Merchant & Cubuk, DeepMind, 2023

"GraphCast, a state-of-the-art AI model able to make medium-range weather forecasts with unprecedented accuracy. GraphCast predicts weather conditions up to 10 days in advance ***more accurately and much faster than the industry gold-standard weather simulation system****."* [41]

— **GraphCast**,
Google, 2023

[41] GraphCast: AI model for faster and more accurate global weather forecasting - Google, 2023

"FourCastNet 3 delivers forecasting accuracy that surpasses leading conventional ensemble models and rivals the best diffusion-based methods, while ***producing forecasts 8 to 60 times faster*** *than these approaches.*

... a strong candidate for improving meteorological forecasting and early warning systems." [42]

— **FourCastNet**,
NVIDIA, 2025

[42] FourCastNet 3: A geometric approach to probabilistic machine-learning weather forecasting at scale - BONEV ET AL., 2025

Healthcare - Drug Discovery

Idiopathic pulmonary fibrosis (IPF) is a type of chronic scarring lung disease characterized by a progressive and irreversible decline in lung function affecting around 5 million people globally. [43]

... This is the first time an ***AI-designed drug*** *for an AI-discovered disease-associated target* ***has been tested in the clinic*** *[phase 2a].* [44]

— **TNIK Inhibitor**,
Insilico, 2025

[43] TNIK Inhibitor: Treating Fibrotic diseases (Phase IIa completed) - Insilico, 2025

[44] A Phase 2 Readout Generates Excitement for the Potential of AI-Driven Drug Discovery - Insilico, 2025

"Using advanced statistical learning methods and a process known as 'joint learning,' the researchers' AI model was able to identify a specific set of proteins that form a general pattern for diseases involving brain degeneration.

Vogel confirms that their ***AI model outperforms previous models, while also being able to diagnose five different dementia-related conditions****: Alzheimer's disease, Parkinson's disease, ALS, frontotemporal dementia, and previous stroke."* [45]

— **New AI model can detect multiple cognitive brain diseases from a single blood sample**, Lund University, 2026

[45] New AI model can detect multiple cognitive brain diseases from a single blood sample - Lund University, 2026

"The AI tool was trained and validated in 72,000 patients from nine NHS trusts in England, who were followed up for a decade after their CT scans. ***It predicted their risk of developing heart failure in the next five years with 86% accuracy.****"* [46, 47]

— **Early Prediction of Heart Failure From Routine Cardiac CT Using Radiomic Phenotyping of Epicardial Fat**, Oikonomou et al., Journal of the American College of Cardiology, 2026

[46] Scientists develop AI tool to spot heart failure risk five years before it strikes - A. Gregory, The Guardian, 2026

[47] Early Prediction of Heart Failure From Routine Cardiac CT Using Radiomic Phenotyping of Epicardial Fat - Oikonomou et al., Journal of the American College of Cardiology, 2026

*"**students learn more than twice as much** in less time with an AI tutor compared to an active learning classroom, while also being more engaged and motivated."* [48]

— **AI tutoring outperforms in-class active learning**,
Nature, 2025

[48] AI tutoring outperforms in-class active learning: an RCT introducing a novel research-based design in an authentic educational setting - Kestin et al., Nature, Scientific Reports, 2025

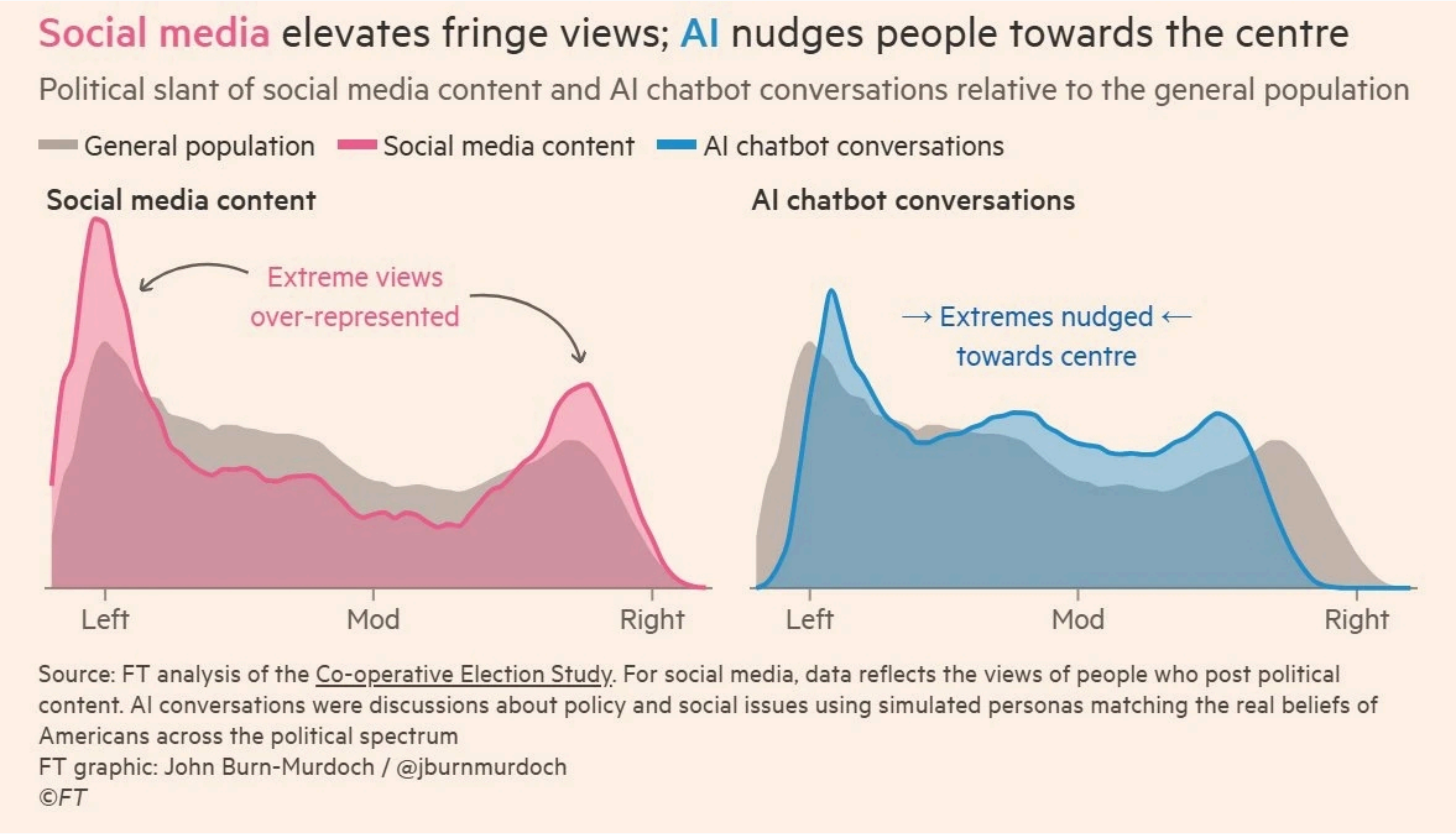
"Our results show that personalized sequencing improves outcomes compared to fixed sequencing by 0.15 standard deviations on an in-person written exam completed without AI assistance, ***which translates into as much as 6-9 months of additional schooling*** *according to some estimates. Notably, these gains were achieved without increasing instruction time or teacher workload. Furthermore, our mediation analysis suggests that these gains are mediated* ***by increased student engagement****"* [49]

— **Effective Personalized AI Tutors via LLM-Guided Reinforcement Learning**, Bastani et al., 2026

[49] Effective Personalized AI Tutors via LLM-Guided Reinforcement Learning - Bastani et al., Preprint, 2026

Soften Polarization

- **AI may help to soften polarization**.



[50] Social media is populist and polarising; AI may be the opposite - Financial Times, 2026

6. Negative Impacts

Environmental Risks - Local Impact

- **While data centers are not a concern on a global scale, they can severely impact local communities**. Their development can harm nearby communities through water use, air pollution, noise, competition for land, and energy cost increases. They can also reduce local tax revenues and typically do not provide other benefits such as high-paying jobs. [51], [52]

[51] From Energy Use to Air Quality, the Many Ways Data Centers Affect US Communities - Walker and Goldsmith, World Resources Institute, 2026

[52] What happens when data centers come to town? - Nguyen & Green, University of Michigan, 2025

*"... **residents report that they have had respiratory issues flare up** since xAI moved in.*

... Using satellite data, researchers at the University of Tennessee at Knoxville found that levels of nitrogen dioxide — which causes smog and is associated with asthma and other respiratory problems — near Colossus have been substantially elevated since its public announcement." [53]

— **Inside the Dirty, Dystopian World of AI Data Centers**,
The Atlantic, 2026

[53] Inside the Dirty, Dystopian World of AI Data Centers - M Wong, The Atlantic, 2026

"A new data center being built with investments from Google will be partly powered by a natural gas project that emits the yearly emissions ***equivalent of putting more than 970,000 additional gas-powered cars on the road****."* [54]

— **A New Google-Funded Data Center Will Be Powered by a Massive Gas Plant**, Wired, 2026

[54] A New Google-Funded Data Center Will Be Powered by a Massive Gas Plant - Taft et al., Wired, 2026

- **Carbon emissions from AI are negligible compared to other sources**. Additionally, this technology has the potential to develop new materials [55], fund small nuclear reactors [56], and improve transportation planning and routing [57], which could contribute to reducing carbon emissions overall.

[55] Millions of new materials discovered with deep learning - Merchant & Cubuk, DeepMind, 2023

[56] These nuclear companies are leading the race to build advanced small reactors in the U.S. - S. Kimball, CNBC, 2025

[57] GreenLight, Using Google AI to reduce traffic emissions - Google, 2025

> *"**All data centers combined account for about 0.5% of global carbon emissions**.* [58] *Of that, ~10% is AI-related, so AI is responsible for 0.05% of global carbon emissions. Cars and other transportation account for 25% of total emissions."* [59]
>
> — **A. Holub**, 2026

[58] AI and climate change - International Energy Agency (IEA), 2025

[59] A. Holub, 2026

- **AI has demonstrated significant user deskilling**.

> *"AI use impairs conceptual understanding, code reading, and debugging abilities, [17% lower] without delivering significant efficiency gains on average."* [60]
>
> — **How AI Impacts Skill Formation**, Anthropic, 2026

> *"continuous exposure to AI for polyp detection [potentially cancerous] reduced the adenoma detection rate…with a 6.0% absolute difference, suggesting a detrimental effect on endoscopist capability."* [61]
>
> — **Rapid generative AI rollout in health care**, The Lancet, 2025

[60] How AI Impacts Skill Formation - Shen & Tamkin, arXiv, Anthropic, 2026

[61] Rapid generative AI rollout in health care - The Lancet Digital Health, 2025

"EEG analysis presented robust evidence that LLM, Search Engine and Brain-only groups had significantly different neural connectivity patterns, reflecting divergent cognitive strategies.

***Brain connectivity systematically scaled down with the amount of external support**: the Brain-only group exhibited the strongest, widest-ranging networks, Search Engine group showed intermediate engagement, and LLM assistance elicited the weakest overall coupling."* [62]

— **Your Brain on ChatGPT**,
Kosmyna et al., 2025

[62] Your Brain on ChatGPT: Accumulation of Cognitive Debt when Using an AI Assistant for Essay Writing Task - Kosmyna et al., arXiv, 2025

"Our findings demonstrate that people readily incorporate AI-generated outputs into their decision-making processes, ***often with minimal friction or skepticism****.*

These findings raise important questions about how decision-makers engage with AI under conditions of uncertainty or error. For example, in contexts such as financial advice, medical triage, or legal decision support, uncritical evaluation of System 3 ***could result in significant harm and a lack of personal accountability for serious life outcomes.****"* [63]

— **Thinking-Fast, Slow, and Artificial: How AI is Reshaping Human Reasoning and the Rise of Cognitive Surrender**, University of Pennsylvania, 2026

[63] Thinking-Fast, Slow, and Artificial: How AI is Reshaping Human Reasoning and the Rise of Cognitive Surrender - Shaw & Nave, University of Pennsylvania, 2026

"If you focus on just driving out results at the limit of whatever AI can do right now, you're only caring about the intercept, you know. ***So I think it's basically a path to obsolescence through both the company and the people who are in it****. And so I'm really surprised how many executives of big companies are pushing this now ...*

... ***They're basically setting up their companies to be destroyed.****"* [64]

— **Jeremy Howard**,
The Dangerous Illusion of AI Coding?, 2026

[64] The Dangerous Illusion of AI Coding? - Jeremy Howard, 2026

So the default behavior is very similar to a self driving car. But there's this tipping point where at some point, you're not engaged anymore. You're not paying attention. And ***you get this delegation of competence. And you get understanding debt.***

... But what happens is that the default attractor is for people to just go into this autopilot mode and they've got no idea what's happening and ***it's actually making them dumber****".* [64]

— **Jeremy Howard**,
The Dangerous Illusion of AI Coding?, 2026

Echo Chamber (Sycophancy Again)

"We have provided both theoretical and empirical results showing that AI systems providing information that is informed by the user's hypotheses result in increased confidence in those hypotheses ***while not bringing the user any closer to the truth****."* [65]

— **A Rational Analysis of the Effects of Sycophantic AI**,
Batista et al., 2026

[65] A Rational Analysis of the Effects of Sycophantic AI - Batista et al., arXiv, 2026

*"More than 5 million US youth (13.1%) have sought mental health advice from AI, **with rates reaching 22.2% among 18- to 21-year-olds**. A 2025 study of adults with mental health conditions who use large language models reported nearly half use them for support, including for anxiety, depression, and personal advice. Users seek emotional support, companionship, psychoeducation, and help processing difficult experiences, likely between sessions and **sometimes instead of clinical care altogether**."* [66]

— **Patients Use AI-Clinicians Should Ask How**,
JAMA Psychiatry, 2026

[66] Patients Use AI-Clinicians Should Ask How - K. Saba & B. Weeks, JAMA Psychiatry, 2026

"The condition doesn't appear in the standard medical literature — because it doesn't exist. It's the invention of a team led by Almira Osmanovic Thunström, a medical researcher at the University of Gothenburg, Sweden, who dreamt up the skin condition and then uploaded two fake studies about it to a preprint server in early 2024.

... Even more troublingly, other researchers say, ***the fake papers were then cited in peer-reviewed literature****."* [67]

— **Scientists invented a fake disease. AI told people it was real**,
Nature, Feature News, 2026

[67] Scientists invented a fake disease. AI told people it was real - C. Stokel-Walker, Nature, Feature News, 2026

The real danger to society is not that AI will actually become conscious, **but rather the risks that arise from *believing* it is**. We may grant legal rights or moral consideration to AI systems, or AI could be used to manipulate human users for commercial or **political gain**. [68, 69, 70, 71]

> *"Fusing LLM reasoning with multiagent architectures, these systems are capable of coordinating autonomously, infiltrating communities, and fabricating consensus efficiently.* ***By adaptively mimicking human social dynamics, they threaten democracy****."* [72]
>
> — **How malicious AI swarms can threaten democracy**, Science, 2026

[68] Illusions of AI consciousness - Bengio & Elmoznino, Science, 2025

[69] 'Unethical' AI research on Reddit under fire - C. O'Grady, Science News, 2025

[70] AI deepfakes blur reality in 2026 US midterm campaigns - Ax & Coster, Reuters, 2026

[71] DHS is using Google and Adobe AI to make videos - J. O'Donnell, MIT Technology Review, 2026

[72] How malicious AI swarms can threaten democracy - Schroeder et al., Science, 2026

"In debate pairs where AI and humans were not equally persuasive, ***GPT-4 with personalization was more persuasive 64.4% of the time****...Our findings highlight the power of LLM-based persuasion and have implications for the governance and design of online platforms."* [73]

— **On the conversational persuasiveness of GPT-4**, Nature, 2025

"I do not fear the rise of superintelligence.

I do, however, fear the rise of billionaires, organizations, and world powers who seek to use computing to maximize their power, influence, and control." [74]

— **Grady Booch**, Creator of UML
Author of the "Object-Oriented Analysis and Design" book

[73] On the conversational persuasiveness of GPT-4 - Salvi et al., Nature Human Behaviour, 2025
[74] Grady Booch - Bluesky, 2026